China. By about 10,000 BC (BCE) to 5000 BC (BCE), agriculture had come to be practised in these regions.



Wheat, barley and peas were cultivated around 10,000 years ago. Fruit and nut trees were cultivated around 4,000 BC (BCE). They comprised olives, figs, dates, pomegranates and grapes.

Fertile Crescent Region refers to the area covering Egypt, Israel-Palestine and Iraq, which is in the shape of crescent moon.

Neolithic Age is called the 'new age', because of the new grinding and polishing techniques used for the tools. The Neolithic people also used the flaked stone tools. Until the Mesolithic period, people mainly hunted and gathered food for their subsistence. By hunting and gathering people obtained very limited food as a result of which only a small number of people could exist in a particular region.

The introduction of domestication of animals and cultivating plants at home led to production and supply of large quantities of grains and animal food. The fertile soil deposited by the river on its banks helped the growth of agriculture. People preferred to live on river banks as it was better for adaptation. As a result of domestication and cultivating plants, there was an excess food production. The surplus food production was a main factor for the development of early civilisations. Permanent residences were built and large villages emerged as a result. Hence, the development of this period is called Neolithic Revolution.

1.4 Prehistoric Tamilagam

Lower Paleolithic Culture in Tamil Nadu

One of the oldest Stone Age tools in the world made by human ancestors, called **hominins,** had been produced in Tamil Nadu. These stone tools are found near the Chennai region at several sites, especially at Athirampakkam. The **archaeological excavations** at this site and **cosmic-ray exposure dating** of the artefacts suggest that people lived here about 1.5 to 2 million years ago. The Kosasthalaiyar river is one of the major cradles of human ancestors in the world. The people who lived here belonged to the species of *Homo erectus*.

Archaeological excavation refers to digging undertaken to recover archaeological evidence such as stone tools, pottery, animal bones and pollens, in order to understand the past lifestyle of humans.

Cosmic-ray exposure dating – method in which exposure to cosmogenic rays is done for dating the samples.

In 1863, Sir Robert Bruce Foote, a geologist from England, first discovered Paleolithic tools at Pallavaram near Chennai. They are the earliest finds of such tools in India. Hence, the hand axe assemblages were considered the **Madras Stone Tool Industry.** The tools that he discovered are now housed in the Chennai Museum.

The Paleolithic people hunted wild animals and gathered the naturally available fruits, roots, nuts and leaves. They did not have knowledge of iron and pottery making, which developed much later in history.

Hand axes and cleavers are the important tool types of the Lower Paleolithic period. These tools fitted with a wooden and bone handle were used for cutting, piercing and digging. The people of this time used hammer stones and spheroids. The quartzite pebbles and cobbles were chosen as raw materials. The tools are found in the soil deposits and also in the exposed river side. They occur at Pallavaram, Gudiyam cave, Athirampakkam, Vadamadurai, Erumaivettipalayam and Parikulam.

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